Introduction to ACAPS Risk Methodology

A general, forward-looking approach to identifying and prioritising potential humanitarian deterioration

Core concept

Risk is the combination of the **probability that a hazard will materialise** and the **expected impact if it does**:

Risk = Probability × Impact

Impact considers expected exposure, hazard intensity, people's vulnerability, and their coping capacity or resilience. Probability estimates the likelihood of the hazard occurring within a defined timeframe.

Key terms

- **Hazard:** a potential event or development that could cause humanitarian consequences.
- **Trigger:** an observable change that signals the likelihood or potential impact of a hazard may be increasing or decreasing.
- **Impact:** the expected humanitarian consequences, including changes in the level or type of needs.
- **Exposure:** the people who may require additional assistance as a direct result.
- **Vulnerability and coping capacity:** the conditions and resources that shape how severely people may be affected.

Analytical process

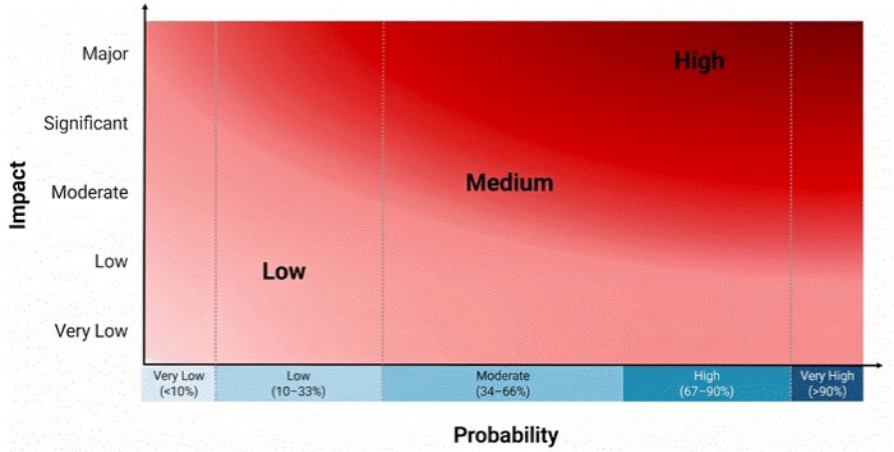
The analysis follows six steps:

1. Develop a situation analysis of the context, drivers of change, vulnerabilities, and response capacity
2. Identify hazards that could lead to humanitarian deterioration
3. Estimate potential impact
4. Estimate probability
5. Classify and prioritise risks
6. Monitor developments and revise the assessment as evidence changes.

Identifying and prioritising risks

Risk identification draws on **continuous monitoring** of quantitative data and qualitative reporting across relevant sectors. Sources may include humanitarian assessments, population and displacement data, market and food-security monitoring, health and nutrition surveillance, climate and hazard information, service availability, access constraints, and political, economic, social, or security developments. Analysts triangulate sources to identify **emerging patterns** and **triggers**; individual indicators are signals for further review, not proof of deterioration on their own.

Not every monitored issue becomes a featured risk: prioritisation considers the likelihood and severity of humanitarian consequences, the populations exposed, and relevance to decision-makers.



Scoring, uncertainty, and outputs

Probability and impact are each assessed on a 1–5 scale and combined to determine an overall risk level. **Scores support comparison and prioritisation; they do not mean an event is certain.** Risk analysis is inherently uncertain, so assumptions and information gaps should be explicit, and assessments updated as new evidence emerges.

A **risk profile** typically includes a rationale, triggers, risk level and scores, timeframe, projected humanitarian impacts, pre-existing vulnerabilities and coping capacities, and **updates added every month**.

Likely impacts may include displacement, reduced access to essential goods or services, market disruption, protection concerns, or compounding effects on vulnerable groups.